opponents. Social media bots can amplify messages and create artificial trends, potentially manipulating public opinion and swaying undecided voters. The sophistication of AI-powered propaganda makes it increasingly difficult to discern truth from fiction, posing a significant threat to informed decision-making during elections.

Beyond voter targeting and persuasion, AI can also revolutionise campaign strategies in other ways. Sentiment analysis tools can gauge public opinion and identify rising issues, allowing campaigns to adapt their messaging and focus on what matters most to voters. AI-powered chatbots can handle routine inquiries and provide information to voters 24/7, freeing up human resources for more critical tasks. Data-driven models can predict voter turnout and optimise resource allocation, making campaigns more efficient and cost-effective.

By combining these AI-driven tools, it is possible to create highly targeted disinformation campaigns, tailoring fake news and propaganda to specific demographics or regions based on their online behaviour and social media activity. This can lead to the spread of false narratives about candidates or issues, influencing voter choices. Deepfakes, manipulated videos and audio recordings can be used to create convincing but fake portrayals of candidates or events.

In addition, AI-powered bots can be used to flood social media platforms with fake accounts that amplify specific messages, create artificial trends and manipulate public opinion. This can give the impression of widespread support for certain candidates or issues, even if it's not genuine. Sentiment analysis tools can be used to identify and target vulnerable demographics, such as young voters or marginalised groups, with tailored propaganda that exploits their anxieties or biases. AI could also be used to hack into the personal data of candidates, voters and campaign officials, exposing sensitive information and potentially using it for blackmail or other malicious purposes.

There are even more threatening scenarios. Democratic societies can now be manipulated by foreign actors using AI-driven social media campaigns. These foreign actors could also use AI to launch cyberattacks on election infrastructure, such as voting machines and voter databases, potentially manipulating votes or disrupting the voting process altogether. The sophistication of AI tools makes it increasingly difficult to detect and attribute malicious activity to foreign actors. This can hamper efforts to hold them accountable and prevent future interference.

It is acknowledged that foreign actors interfered in the US 2016 and 2020 presidential elections as well as the mid-term elections in the Philippines. Foreign governments and their affiliated troll farms used AI-powered bots to flood social media platforms with a network of fake accounts and misleading content aimed at manipulating public opinion. These bots amplified certain messages, created the illusion of widespread support for specific candidates and spread harmful stereotypes and conspiracies against other candidates.

Given the impact that AI is likely to have on our elections, it is vital to implement several measures immediately. First, robust cybersecurity measures are necessary to protect election infrastructure and voter data from cyberattacks. Second, voters must develop their media literacy and critical thinking skills to help them identify and resist misinformation and propaganda. Third, we must strengthen international cooperation and information-sharing among democracies to combat foreign interference in elections.

Finally, we should formulate regulations and ethical guidelines for the use of AI in political campaigns that can help to mitigate the risks of misuse and ensure transparency. This includes regulations on data collection and usage, as well as mechanisms for independent audits and fact-checking of online content. All election content should also be clearly watermarked with authenticated political parties, candidates or registered media. Voters will then be able to distinguish between verified content and potential disinformation.

The impact of AI on our elections is undeniable. It can revolutionise campaign strategies, personalise voter outreach and even influence public opinion. AI can provide voters with targeted information about their candidates and various political parties. However, the potential benefits come with serious risks that need to be addressed. Bharat has been a global leader in conducting free and fair elections. By embracing transparency, digital literacy and regulation, we can ensure that AI becomes a force for good, strengthening our democracy and empowering our citizens in the Amrit Kaal ahead. ■

Views are personal

TAKEAWAYS

- AI will enhance voter targeting and persuasion in political campaigns and the possibility of manipulation
- Transparency, regulation and digital literacy are critical
- The sophistication of AI-powered propaganda makes it increasingly difficult to discern truth from fiction, posing a threat to informed decision-making